violence and peaceful non-cooperation and civil disobedience, were instrumental in achieving India's independence from the much-hated British Raj'.[1] In his recent book on Har Dayal, who set up the Ghadar Party (i.e. 'rebellion' party) in San Francisco on 1 November 1913, in what he describes as 'the largest international anti-colonial resistance movement',[2] Bhuvan Lall says of Bhagat Singh that he of all people had through his actions 'redeemed and somewhat exceeded the anticolonial objectives of the Ghadr of 1857 and the Ghadr movement in California'.[3] How did Bhagat Singh manage to do that?

First, Bhagat Singh drew from a far wider and deeper source of influences for his convictions than Gandhi ever did when he refers to actions of men such as Washington and Garibaldi, Lafayette and Lenin. This is how Bhagat Singh became the ultimate rationalist in the Indian revolutionary struggle. What distinguished him from other revolutionaries of the time was how, having started off life in the burning embers of insurgent Lyallpur and Lahore, his political development was ultimately refashioned, remoulded and refined by the vast array of international radical literature into which he immersed himself and imbibed right until the very moment of his hanging. He read not only Marx, Engels and Trotsky but also Thomas Paine, Upton Sinclair, Morris Hillquit and Jack London. He went on to read Victor Hugo, Dostoevsky, Spinoza and Bertrand Russell. Classical works were not overlooked so he also read John Stuart Mill, Thomas Jefferson, Kautsky, Bukharin, Burke, Lenin, Thomas Aquinas, Danton, Omar Khayyam, Tagore, N.A. Morozov, Herbert Spencer, Henry Maine and Rousseau. There is also his famous *Jail Book*, which came to light in 1974, of which Moffat writes that it 'includes fragments copied from the work of some seventy different authors and which can be read in a myriad of ways, emphasising the passages on Marx rather than those on Rousseau . . .' and where one can see 'Bhagat Singh's appreciation of Byron and Tennyson or his interest in natural law'.[4]

Second, he believed in personal sacrifice for the attainment of his ideals, including having to give up his life if necessary. Prison gave him the opportunity to read voraciously. So much so that it is said that he wrote four